

DSC 640 - Data Presentation and Visualization

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Weeks 1 & 2

Term Project - Milestone 1

Analysis of the National Database of Childcare Prices

Summary of Analysis

The National Database of Childcare Prices provides detailed information on childcare costs across different states, counties, and care types. The dataset includes variables such as age groups (infant, toddler, preschool), provider types (center-based vs. home-based care), and pricing metrics. After reviewing the dataset, my analysis focused on comparing childcare costs across regions and identifying trends by age group and provider type.

Findings

- There is significant variation in childcare costs depending on geographic location, with urban and high-cost states showing much higher prices than rural areas.
- Infant care is consistently the most expensive across all regions due to higher care requirements.
- Center-based care is generally more expensive than home-based care, though it may provide more structured programs.
- Childcare costs consume a large percentage of household income in some regions, indicating affordability challenges for families.

Assumptions

- The dataset reflects accurate and reasonably recent pricing trends, even if some data may not be fully up to date.
- Cost reporting is consistent across different regions.
- External factors such as subsidies, tax credits, or informal childcare are not fully captured in the dataset.

Items That Still Need Clarification

- How frequently is the dataset updated?
- Does the data reflect seasonal or economic fluctuations?
- How was the pricing data collected and validated?

- Does the dataset account for quality differences in childcare services?

Direction of Story / Plan of Attack / Message

The primary message is that childcare affordability is a significant issue, with costs varying widely based on location and type of care. The story will highlight disparities and emphasize how childcare expenses impact working families. Key comparisons such as state vs. national averages and infant vs. preschool costs will be used to make the data relatable and actionable.

Target Audience

The target audience includes non-technical stakeholders such as policymakers, organizational leaders, and working parents. The presentation will be simple, clear, and focused on key insights to support decision-making.

Mediums

- **Interactive Dashboard** – A dashboard that allows users to explore childcare costs by state, age group, and provider type using filters and summary metrics.
- **Summary Report** – A concise written report highlighting key findings, trends, and recommendations.
- **Presentation Slides** – A visual slide deck using charts and simple visuals to communicate key insights and implications.